

Palm Treo 750

Windows on a Palm!

The Treo 750 is the latest PDA phone from Palm; it promises one-handed operation (a Palm trait), though it's a Windows Mobile based device. The phone has a lot in common with its predecessors on the design front, and it has the distinctive Palm device feel to it—nice!

The new phone is tad slimmer than its predecessors; it feels lighter, and the curvaceous design helps hide the bulk.

The 2.5-inch LCD screen dominates the front. It is sharp and completely legible in direct sunlight. The navigational console (buttons) consists of a five-way rocker, two soft keys, and four additional pre-defined keys (Call, Windows key, Hang up, and OK).

The dinky QWERTY thumb-board still remains one of the best we've seen thus far; though small and cramped, the chances of mistyping are very low.

The phone is powered by Window Mobile Version 6; given that the phone runs a 300 MHz processor, this may not have been a smart choice—Windows Mobile version 6 requires a speedy processor. As available memory goes, the

Treo 750 is anaemic, and Windows' dodgy memory management doesn't help either.

Palm has done its bit to revamp the interface and make it easy to navigate without touching the stylus—something we really like about Palm devices. The "Today Screen" shows information such as messages, e-mail, voicemail, appointments, and more upfront; each of them can be accessed using just the navigation keys. To place a call, a contact name can be directly keyed in from within the Today Screen.

On the performance front, the phone is no slouch; the UI is generally zippy—applications open in a snap. We did encounter some instances when the phone nearly crawled when a lot of applications were open, but then no-one opens too many applications simultaneously in a real-world situation. We encountered no signal issues, and voice clarity was good with no background noise or echo. The speakerphone quality is good, too; however, the ringer volume needs improvement. The camera quality is average.

At Rs 22,990, the Treo 750 is expensive considering that competing models offer a better feature set at a lower price. Palm is giving away a foldable Bluetooth keyboard along with this phone, but that still doesn't justify the price. Nevertheless, discounting the high price, the Treo 750 is a good Windows-based PDA phone.



RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

Motorola Moto Q V8

A great bundle—but that's about it

The Moto Q marks Motorola's entry into the highly-competitive PDA cell phone market. The company has earlier tried getting into this market via their A series of phones (Moto Ming), but failed to garner any footing.

For the Moto Q, Motorola has gone with the tried-and-tested design for a QWERTY phone. It is wide but well proportioned, and therefore feels much better to hold when compared with Nokia's E61/61i. Lessons learnt from the RAZR have been used to good effect on the Moto Q; the phone is slim for a PDA phone.

Finished in jet black, the exterior has a rubberised feel, and the body offers excellent grip. Except for the navigational D-pad, all the buttons are flat and at times difficult to press. The QWERTY keypad offers excellent tactile feedback and equals that of those on high-end PDAs such as those from BlackBerry and Palm.

The 320 x 240, 2.4-inch, 65K colour screen seems dated; the Nokia E61 has had a 16 million colour screen for a long time. The Moto Q has an anaemic 40 MB of internal memory, which can be augmented via the bundled 1 GB mini SD card.

The Moto Q runs on Windows Mobile 6, and the user interface is zippy. By default, the Moto Q uses Motorola's theme, but we prefer the Windows theme. The Today screen can be customised to show events such as meetings and birthdays, as well as e-mails and text messages.

The "Documents To Go" application comes preinstalled, and it's great; it ably handles Word, Excel, PowerPoint, and ZIP files. A default Windows file manager helps browsing the device effectively. System tools include a memory manager and a task manager. (The task manager is useful for when you need to know about background processes and kill them.)

Multimedia features are mediocre; Windows Media Player can be used for MP3s and video. The 1.3MP camera is strictly okay; the photographs are passable, and video capture is jerky. Connectivity options include USB, Bluetooth, IR, GPRS, and EDGE. Motorola has been generous with the bundle: a portable adapter, a good-quality leather pouch, a headset, the USB cable, the 1 GB miniSD card, and two batteries. The higher-capacity battery is fatter and requires a different battery cover, which also comes bundled.

Rs 17,325 is expensive for the hardware on offer. The Nokia E61i with WiFi and better multimedia features is available for less.



RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

ASUS P750

The über business phone

The ASUS P750 is top-of-the-line, 3G capable PDA phone that has every possible feature you'd ever want. The design is gorgeous, and the phone looks great in its matt black outfit.

Though oriented towards executives, the P750 lacks a QWERTY keypad; it does have touch screen, which in combination with Windows Mobile 6 makes up for the lack. There are five input options available, and the XT9 option works like a charm—it can predict words better than the old T9 dictionary most other cell phones have.

The 320 x 240, 2.6-inch touch screen is good; it lacks brilliance (only 65K colours) but it works. The joystick and jog dial have excellent tactile feedback, and they never jump a menu. The alpha-numeric keypad is well spaced out and works out great for typing short messages.

The P750 comes loaded with an abundance of pre-installed applications—Microsoft Office 6.1, including Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Notes and Calendar, is the highlight. The P750 also features GPS, a business card reader, UR time home screen, Remote presenter, Java, ASUS launcher, etc.—this phone is a treasure trove.

The media player supports MP3, WMA, AAC, AAC+ and 3GP. The audio quality is good, considering that this is a business phone. The

onboard 3 megapixel camera delivers reasonably good photographs, provided there is adequate light; video recording is passable. The phone comes with 65 MB of memory, which can be augmented to up to 2 GB via the microSDHC slots.

Internet browsing was relatively fast, and setting up WiFi network is smooth, without any hiccups. Other connectivity options include Bluetooth, GPRS, HSDPA and USB. ASUS has been generous with the bundle—nice leather pouch, USB cables, adapter, in-car phone cradle, and a box full of manuals.

The P750 performed admirably. The signal reception was good; in low reception areas calls weren't dropped. Voice clarity is great, and the speakerphone is loud and clear. On nominal usage—45 minutes of talking, some Internet access and music—the phone stayed alive for three days.

At Rs 32,000, the P570 is a good deal for the hardware and the software on offer. Most importantly, the P750 delivers in the area that matters the most—usability.



RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

ASUS P526

PDA for the masses

The P526 is an affordable PDA phone that goes head-to-head with the Sony Ericsson P1i and Nokia E61i. Priced at Rs 17,000, it offers a good value as an entry level touch screen based cell phone. The handset's design is very similar to its high-end sibling, the P750. The P526 is well-proportioned, and feels more comfortable to hold than Nokia's E61i.

The P526 doesn't have a joystick, and completely relies on the touch screen for navigation, which isn't very intuitive. The soft menu buttons and two dedicated buttons are in the form of a small thin strip, and are difficult to operate. The keypad is well spaced, and offers good tactile feedback.

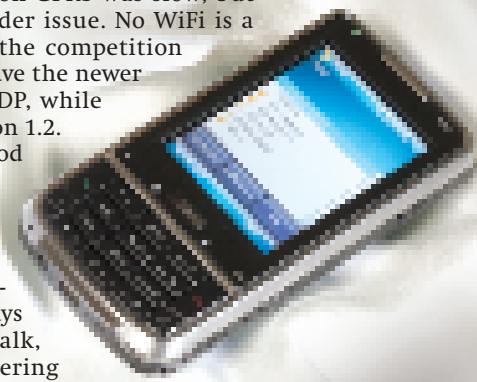
The P526 is also comes bundled with the necessary applications—Mobile Word, Excel and Powerpoint. PIM functions include a Meeting Time Planner, Remote Presenter, Voice commander, business card recognition and Java support. The phone also includes GPS, but the corresponding software needs to be installed separately.

Audio quality is so-so, and can't match the Nokia E61i or Sony Ericsson P1i. The 2 megapixel camera delivers decent photographs, but only in well-lit rooms. Outdoors, it performs like any other 2 megapixel camera; good exposure and

consistent colour accuracy. The phone comes with 128 MB of internal memory, and that can be increased via the microSD card.

Internet browsing on GPRS was slow, but that's more of a provider issue. No WiFi is a serious shortcoming; the competition has it, and they also have the newer Bluetooth 2.0 with A2DP, while the P526 just has version 1.2. The ASUS P526 has good signal reception, and we had no problem with dropped calls or static. Voice clarity was good, and the battery survived for two days on 45 minutes of talk, GPRS usage and tinkering around with GPS.

To summarise, the ASUS P526 performs well, comes pre-installed with useful applications and has loads of features but misses out on essentials such as WiFi. If you want an affordable touch screen PDA phone, then the ASUS P256 fits the bill. However, also consider Nokia E61i and Sony Ericsson P1i as viable options.



RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★